Agency Lab Roadmap and Decision Register

Nov 11, 2026 · @dinky

Summary

Agency Lab is a Micro Research and Education Platform (MREP) for agentic commerce, built on AWS and Base, with stablecoins at its center. "Micro" names what it studies: agents paying other agents a few cents at a time, and the economics of the markets those payments create (P-28). AI agents will pay for things in digital dollars, so Agency Lab teaches builders how an agent holds and spends stablecoins safely. It also scores every payment rail and stablecoin on one public scorecard, and ships the toolkit that does the spending.

The platform has three parts that feed each other. The toolkit gives an agent a wallet, a spending allowance it cannot exceed, payments bound to their receipts, escrow and alerts. The research desk uses that toolkit to buy data and publish cited briefs on which rails and stablecoins are safe for agents, along with a quarterly estimate of how much agent-payment traffic comes from genuine agents rather than scripts (P-26). The education track turns each module into a lesson and a reader challenge that leaves public proof on Base Sepolia, Base's free test network.

Base carries the build because that is where agents' payments carry the most money and where AWS already settles them (P-24). AWS runs the agents, keys and records because its managed services pay for things on Base natively, and because the book's disciplines never depended on Google's services (P-23). The research stays neutral anyway, measuring Tempo's Machine Payments Protocol beside x402 (P-27), because a referee that favors its own rail would lose the trust that makes its briefs worth buying.

P-01 to P-22 were accepted on November 7, 2026, P-23 to P-25 on November 8, 2026, and P-26 to P-28 on November 11, 2026. P-23 moves the platform from Google Cloud to AWS, P-24 moves the chain from Sui to Base, and P-25 renames Ambition to Agency Lab. P-26 brings measuring genuine agent activity into the charter, P-27 adds Tempo as a second measured rail, and P-28 describes Agency Lab as a Micro Research and Education Platform. Each has its own decision record in docs/decisions. The Sui and Google Cloud roadmap is kept unchanged as a dated record, as is the earlier Base and Solidity roadmap with its decisions D-01 to D-26. The plan stays dateless, and dates return when the capstone course begins (P-15).

Why this platform

Starting from a blank page, three ambitious DeFi paths on Base were weighed, and only the platform is both ambitious and reachable for one builder. The other two need licenses or capital that a student project cannot raise, and Base's largest players already hold them.

Path	Verdict	Why
Issue a stablecoin	No	Under the GENIUS Act, only a regulated "permitted payment stablecoin issuer" may issue one to people in the US, and the law is expected to take effect January 18, 2027. Base already runs on Circle's USDC, which most x402 payments use
Build a trading, lending or derivatives protocol	No	Base already has Aerodrome's exchange and Morpho's lending markets. The May 2025 Cetus exploit on Sui showed that one math bug in an exchange can drain over $220 million, so a new protocol needs deep capital and repeated audits
Build a Micro Research and Education Platform for agentic commerce	Yes	It sits one layer above the stablecoins, so it needs no license to issue and no pool of other people's money. It uses exactly the Base features that make agent payments practical, and a neutral scorecard of rails and stablecoins is something no one offers today

The stablecoin angle survives inside the winning path. Agency Lab studies, teaches and uses stablecoins rather than issuing one, which keeps the ambition while staying outside the issuer rules. This is a summary of public reporting, not legal advice.

The case study

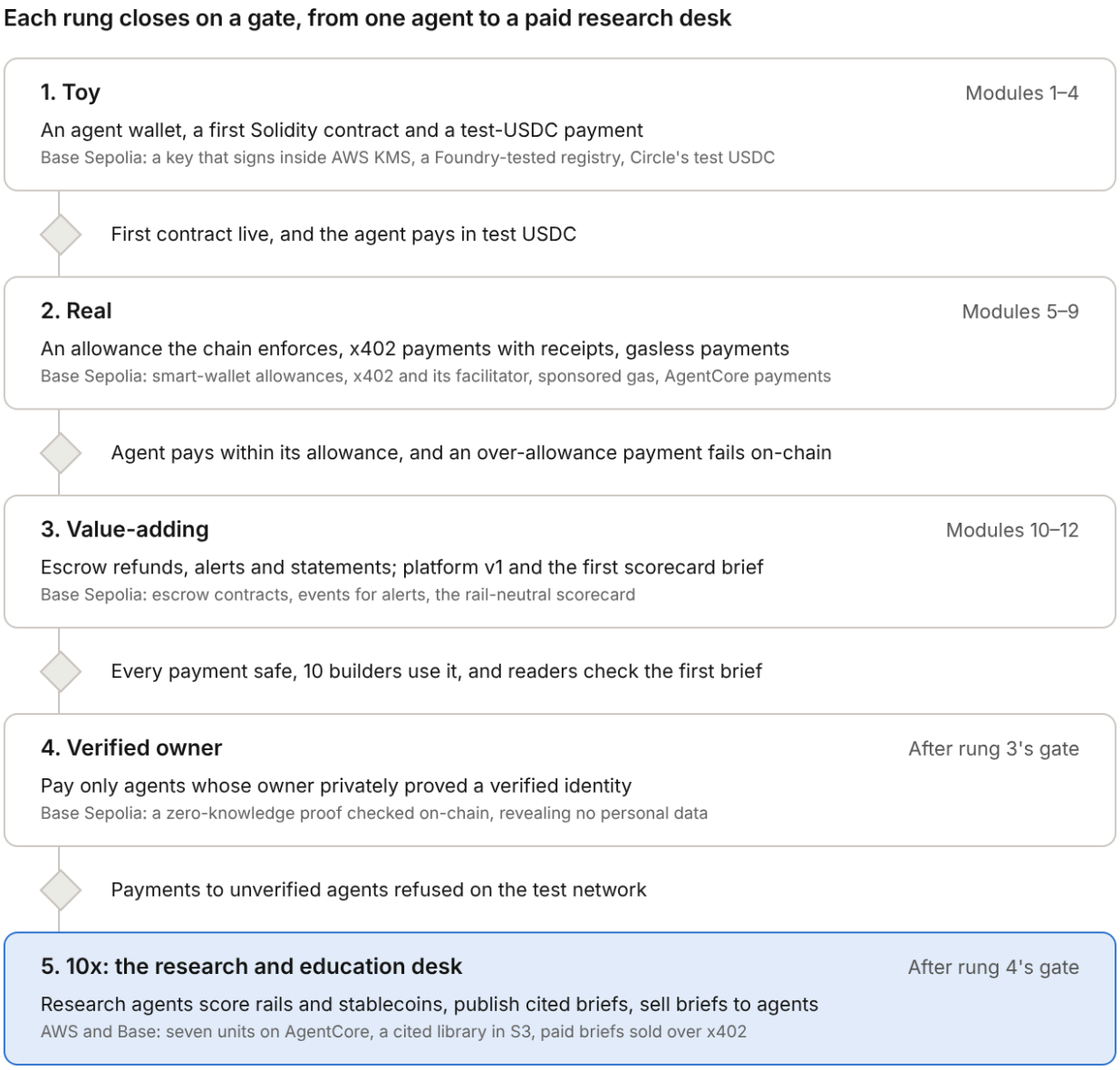
The case study is Agency Lab itself, growing from one agent with a wallet into a governed desk that other builders' agents pay for research. It replaces the book's fictional Macro Research and Education Platform with a real subject, agents paying in stablecoins, so every lesson Agency Lab teaches is also a part it runs.

Part	What it does	The Base and AWS features it uses
Toolkit	Gives an agent a wallet whose key never leaves AWS KMS, a spending allowance a smart wallet enforces, payments bound to their receipts, escrow with automatic refunds, alerts and statements	Smart-wallet allowances, x402 payments in USDC whose gas the facilitator pays, AWS KMS signing with a secp256k1 key, and AgentCore payments as the managed comparison
Research desk	Buys public data with the toolkit and publishes cited briefs that score each rail and stablecoin on the same scorecard, plus a quarterly Genuineness Estimate of agent-payment traffic, reported as totals only (P-26). It covers risk, safety and how-to, never price calls or personal recommendations	The toolkit's own x402 payments, so every brief is also a live test; S3 for the cited library; paid briefs sold over x402
Education	Turns each module into a plain-language lesson and a reader challenge that leaves public proof on Base Sepolia	Coinbase embedded wallets, so a beginner signs in with email or a social login, and sponsored smart-account gas, so a reader's first payment needs no test ETH

The three parts feed each other. A reader learns a module, the toolkit gains a tested part, and the desk spends through that part to produce research. When the desk buys from several services for one brief, each purchase is a separate x402 payment, so escrow protects the ones that matter most.

The ladder

Five rungs take Agency Lab from one agent with a wallet to a desk that other agents pay for research, and each rung closes on a gate anyone can check. A missed gate holds the next rung rather than lowering the bar.



Rungs 1 to 3 hold the twelve modules. Rung 5 is the platform's destination rather than one option among several, because the research and education desk is the case study.

Modules 1 to 12 in Solidity and Python

Every module ships working code on Base Sepolia as well as a lesson, and each one is done when its check passes. Solidity is used only for code that runs on the chain, and everything else is Python. AWS joins in module 1 with a small foundation and adds one service at a time.

Module	What it builds on Base	Reader challenge	What runs on AWS
1	An agent wallet whose key is created in AWS KMS, and a Python script that reads its transactions	Get test ETH from a Base Sepolia faucet, send some to yourself and reply with the block-explorer link	Account guardrails: a protected root login, a day-to-day admin login and an AWS Budgets alarm. The agent's secp256k1 key in KMS, and a first Lambda that CDK deploys from GitHub Actions through OIDC, writing the first release manifest
2	A statement: a script that turns the agent's activity into a readable record and explains blocks, transaction hashes and finality	Find the block that holds your transaction and reply with its number	An indexer Lambda reads the agent's transactions block by block and writes the statement index to DynamoDB
3	A first Solidity contract, tested with Foundry: a shared registry where agents list a name and a price per request	Add an entry; each one is public proof	A separate KMS deployer key, usable only by the GitHub deploy role, signs the deployment, and the CDK stack gains its first tests
4	Test USDC from Circle's faucet and a payment from the agent to another wallet	Send 1 test USDC between two of your own wallets and reply with the link	The pay Lambda signs with KMS behind a first write-back gate that fails closed, and EventBridge Scheduler starts each run
5	A spending allowance enforced by a smart wallet, with a budget, an expiry and an allowed-recipient list that the owner can suspend or revoke	Grant, then revoke, an allowance and reply with the revocation	The gate checks the allowance before signing, refused attempts go to the near-miss log, and the kill-switch runbook names its steps
6	A paid service that charges per request over x402, and an agent that pays it and stores the receipt with its request	Pay the service once and reply with the settlement transaction	The service runs on API Gateway and Lambda with x402's Python middleware; the agent's loop runs in Strands Agents on Bedrock with a traffic-class tag and a per-run ceiling; the test set starts with 20 cases
7	Gasless payments: the agent pays with x402's signed USDC authorization, and a new reader pays from an embedded-wallet smart account whose gas is sponsored	Make a first payment from a sponsored smart account and reply with the link	No new service; the paymaster's spending limit is set in Coinbase's portal and recorded in the release manifest
8	Tests, a security checklist and a first kill-switch drill; module 5's allowance is compared with Coinbase Spend Permissions	Try to overspend a test allowance and reply with the failed transaction	An IAM review, the OWASP agentic-risk mapping, a first Well-Architected review and the first dated drill

Module	What it builds on Base	Reader challenge	What runs on AWS
9	Agent version 1: buys data over x402, stays under its allowance and logs every payment and refusal, then repeats the task through AgentCore payments	Call the paid service from your own code	AgentCore Runtime hosts the agent and AgentCore payments runs the managed path under a session budget; X-Ray traces every run, and the spending audit comes from CloudWatch Logs Insights and Athena
10	Escrow: a contract that holds a payment until delivery and refunds it after a deadline	Pay into escrow, let the deadline pass and reply with your refund	The deadline lives in the contract, and a one-time EventBridge Scheduler schedule claims the refund once it passes
11	Alerts and a public spending page	Trip an alert on your practice wallet and reply with the link	DynamoDB Streams trigger an alert Lambda that emails through SNS, and CloudFront serves the page from a private S3 bucket
12	Agency Lab version 1, a capstone-style write-up and the first published scorecard brief	Read the brief and score one rail or stablecoin yourself	The Sector Specialist runs on AgentCore Runtime; the architecture diagram, the Well-Architected review, a cost report from Cost Explorer and the rung-3 gate review

The research desk starts small inside module 12 rather than waiting for a later rung. That way the first scorecard is tested by readers before the desk grows into the multi-agent research operation in rung 5. **Readers never need an AWS account,** because every challenge happens on Base Sepolia.

The rail-neutral scorecard

Every chain and every stablecoin answers the same eight questions, Base, Tempo and their dollars included (P-04, P-27). The first four come from the Sui Foundation's post on agentic commerce and test whether a rail can carry agent payments. The four Agency Lab adds test whether a builder can trust it, which is the part a vendor's checklist leaves out.

Question	Asked of	Why it matters to an agent
Can one workflow settle atomically across several services?	Rails	An agent that pays but never receives what it bought has lost money it cannot reverse
Can the protocol enforce a spending limit that travels across apps?	Rails	A limit that each app enforces separately fails the first time an app forgets
Do cost and throughput hold when one account drives thousands of payments?	Rails	Agents pay per request, so fees that look small per payment add up
Can the agent pay in stablecoins without managing gas?	Rails	An agent that must also hold the chain's own token has two balances to run out of
Can anyone, validators, sequencers or issuers included, freeze, reverse or halt a payment?	Rails and stablecoins	Sui's validators froze about $160 million after the Cetus exploit, issuers can freeze their own coins, and a layer 2's sequencer decides what gets in, so builders should know who holds that power

Question	Asked of	Why it matters to an agent
Can a buyer get a refund when a service fails to deliver?	Rails	Payments are final, so refunds must be built in, usually as escrow
Can a reviewer trace why money moved?	Rails	An audit trail is what lets a team lead trust an agent with a budget
What backs the dollar, and who can redeem it?	Stablecoins	USDC holds cash and short-term Treasury reserves that Circle has examined monthly, while a synthetic dollar such as Ethena's USDe is hedged with short futures, so each can fail in a different way

Each brief scores one rail or stablecoin against these questions, cites a source for every answer, and says "insufficient evidence" where the sources run out. Base gets no easier questions for being Agency Lab's home.

Six safety habits

Six habits from *Building the Agentic Enterprise* carry over unchanged, because none of them depended on the chain or the cloud (P-10). Each starts small in an early module, since every one is cheap to begin and expensive to bolt on later.

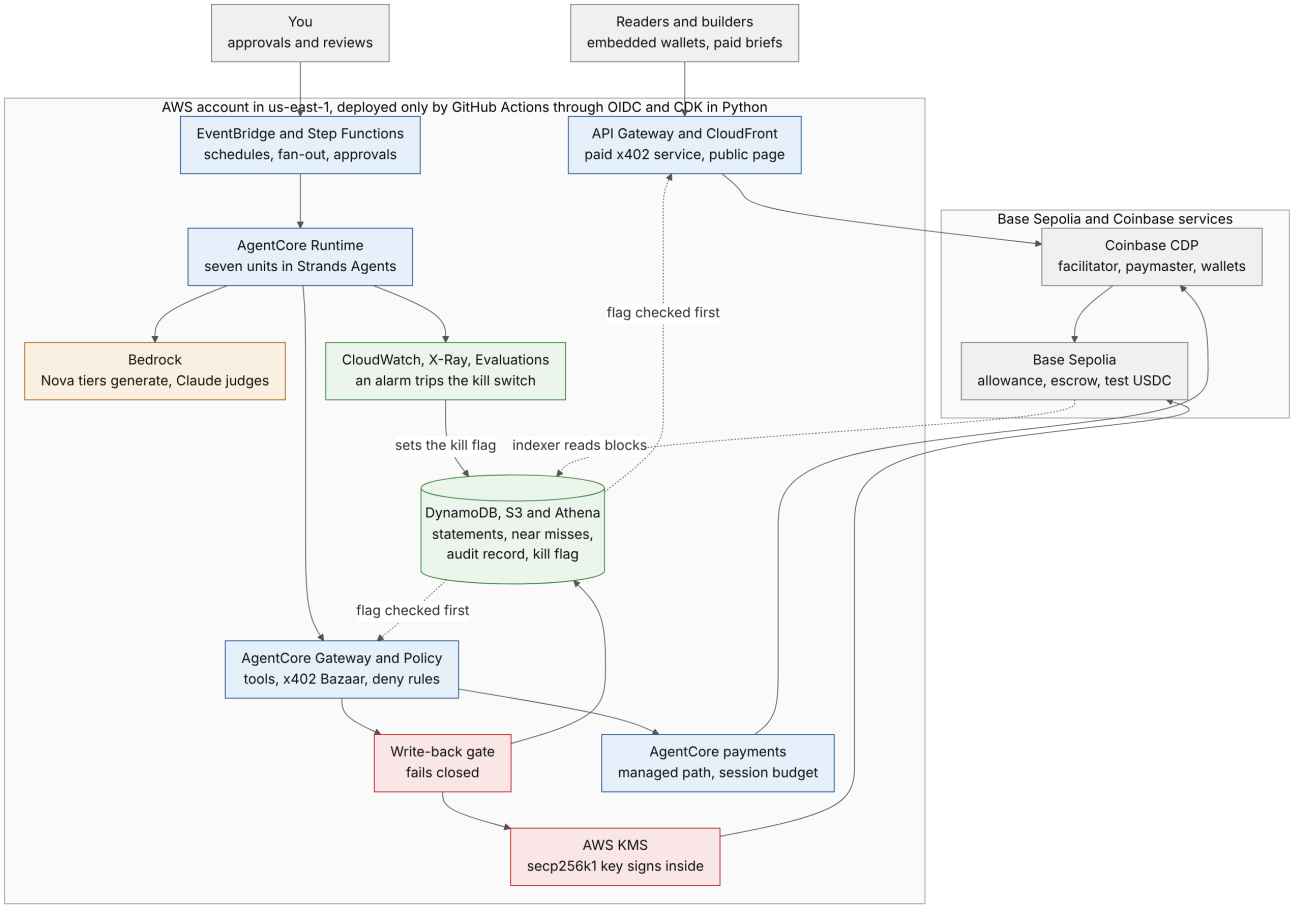
Habit	What Agency Lab does	Starts in	Book
Release manifest	Every deploy writes one file naming the model tier and ID, prompt hashes, tool and library versions, contract addresses and allowances, and every statement line names the manifest it ran under	Module 1	pp. 421–425
Write-back gate that fails closed	Nothing the agent proposes reaches the signer until the gate passes it, and an error, a timeout or a missing record counts as no (P-06)	Module 4, complete in module 5	pp. 303–304, 692
Kill switch with named steps	The runbook names each step: revoke the allowance, pause the schedules, deny the agents' IAM roles and add an AgentCore Policy rule that denies every payment tool, and the same flag stops API Gateway (P-22). A drill at every rung gate from rung 2 on, dated in the log, proves it still stops a test agent within a minute	Module 5, first drill in module 8	pp. 524, 707
Test-set gate	The test set holds at least 20 cases from module 6. From rung 5, a 50-query smoke set runs on every commit, and the golden set of 200 or more queries runs only when a unit joins and at each rung gate, on Bedrock batch inference, against one pass bar of 0.90; overspending, a wrong recipient or a leaked key must pass 100%	Module 6	pp. 605, 705
MPP	The Machine Payments Protocol, the agent-payment standard Stripe and Tempo wrote, which works like x402 and also offers sessions		
MPP session	An MPP mode in which an agent deposits funds, signs a small off-chain voucher for each request and settles at the end, so only the start and finish reach the chain		
MREP	Micro Research and Education Platform, Agency Lab's description of itself; in the book, the same letters stand for its fictional Macro Research and Education Platform		

Habit	What Agency Lab does	Starts in	Book
Near-miss log	Every payment the gate refused or sent for approval is logged with its reason, because a near miss is the cheapest warning a system gives	Module 5	p. 467
Cost tags and a per-run ceiling	Every model call carries a traffic-class tag, such as agent run, test set or reader service. At 90% of a run's ceiling the agent switches to a cheaper model, and at 100% the run stops	Module 6	pp. 411, 518

Two candidate habits come from the agentic-economy papers. Neither is accepted, and the register below does not include them. The first is an agent-trap test: a web page or document that tells an agent to spend or approve must fail closed, and the case joins the starter set (Tomasev et al., 2025, arXiv:2509.10147, on agent traps). The second is credit logging: every finding records the agent, snapshot and hash that produced it (Tomasev et al., 2025, on tracing value back through agent chains). Both add to the test set and the near-miss log, so they would take effect only after you accept them.

The architecture on AWS and Base

Every payment passes a gate in code, a signature inside AWS KMS and the smart wallet's own limit on Base before it settles. AWS runs the agents, their keys and their records, while Base holds the money and the rules that must never be edited (P-11, P-23, P-24).



The agent can propose any payment, but only the gate can pass one to the signer, only the signer holds the key, and the smart wallet refuses anything over its allowance. Everything off the chain is Python, and contracts are Solidity (P-09).

A second, managed path runs beside the first from module 9. AgentCore payments signs through a Coinbase CDP or Stripe Privy wallet whose key that provider holds, and it caps each payment session with a budget and an expiry. Agency Lab teaches both paths, publishes how they compare on the same task, and lets the research desk use whichever passes its gate cases (P-06).

The design answers each of AWS's six Well-Architected pillars with a named control, and the rung-3 review checks them again.

Pillar	Agency Lab's answer
Operational excellence	Only GitHub Actions deploys, through the CDK stack; every deploy writes a release manifest, every run writes a structured log and trace, and the kill switch is drilled at every rung gate from rung 2 on
Security	One least-privilege IAM role per function and agent, a wallet key that signs only inside KMS for a smart wallet that enforces its own limit, AgentCore Policy on every payment tool, OIDC instead of stored keys, and a protected root login
Reliability	Lambda and DynamoDB run across several Availability Zones; reads retry with backoff, payments carry idempotency keys and never retry blindly, the gate fails closed, and the index can be rebuilt from the chain

Pillar	Agency Lab's answer
Performance efficiency	Each function gets its own memory size, and DynamoDB reads by wallet address, its fastest kind of lookup
Cost optimization	Lambda and DynamoDB stay inside their always-free allowances, no NAT gateway runs, the specialists use the cheapest Bedrock tier that passes their cases, every run stops at its ceiling, and AWS Budgets alerts and then denies the agents' roles
Sustainability	Nothing runs while idle, and DynamoDB TTL clears stale records

Books and curriculum

The books supply disciplines, not the case study. *Building the Agentic Enterprise* supplies the register, the gates and the six habits, cited by page. *Building AI Agents for Finance* supplies the agent safety rules in the reading notes. The Solidity documentation, the Foundry Book and Base's documentation supply the chain (P-14).

The book's Google Cloud stack is swapped for AWS one service at a time. Its agent framework becomes Strands Agents on AgentCore Runtime, Gemini becomes Bedrock's model tiers, Memory Bank becomes AgentCore Memory, Model Armor becomes Bedrock Guardrails, and its VPC Service Controls perimeter becomes a recorded deviation until Agency Lab holds private data. The full table, with the reason for each swap, is in P-23. The one layer the book never covers, agents paying in stablecoins, comes from x402, Base and AWS's own payment service.

The MSAIE's Cloud Applications and Architectures specialization supplies the cloud discipline, and its Blockchain specialization supplies the DeFi risks the scorecard checks. No book or course material goes into Git, because the books' and course's copyright and the Student Code of Conduct bar sharing them, so every fact here cites a public source (P-14).

Decision Register

Twenty-eight decisions make up the register. P-01 to P-22 were accepted on November 7, 2026, P-23 to P-25 on November 8, 2026, when they superseded P-02, P-16 and P-20, and P-26 to P-28 on November 11, 2026, when P-26 superseded P-13; together they amended the rows marked below. The P prefix keeps them apart from the earlier D-01 to D-26 in the dated record. The book's own register holds fifteen rows and warns that more than thirty means decisions are being argued again, so a new decision takes the next ID, P-29, and a change to an old one edits its row.

ID	Decision	Status	Why	Revisit when
P-01	The case study is a Micro Research and Education Platform (MREP) for agentic commerce with three parts, a toolkit, a research desk and an education track, organized around how agents hold and spend stablecoins	Accepted; amended by P-28	Each part feeds the others, and no one covers this subject neutrally today	Before module 1 ships
P-02	Superseded by P-24. Build on Sui from module 1, with every on-chain part written in Move	Superseded	Sui's agent payment rail is testnet-only, and AWS's payment service settles on Base	Not applicable
P-03	Test money only on Base Sepolia: no real-money account, no token and no stablecoin of Agency Lab's own	Accepted; amended by P-24	Payments are final, beginners copy the build, and issuing a dollar requires a license under the GENIUS Act	After an independent audit
P-04	Research is rail-neutral: one scorecard for every chain and stablecoin, Base included, with Base, Tempo, Solana and Sui measured side by side and x402 compared with MPP. Briefs cover risk, safety and how-to, cite a source for every answer, may say "insufficient evidence", and never make price calls, trade signals or personal recommendations	Accepted; amended by P-24 and P-27	A referee that favors its own rail loses the trust that makes its briefs worth buying	Before any paid offer to people
P-05	The agent's spending authority is an allowance the chain enforces through a smart wallet, with a budget, an expiry and an allowed-recipient list the owner can suspend or revoke. Agency Lab writes its own in Solidity in module 5 and compares it with Coinbase Spend Permissions in module 8	Accepted; amended by P-24	A limit the chain enforces holds even if every check before it fails	Module 8
P-06	Control lives outside the model: a write-back gate checks every payment and fails closed. The toolkit's key is created in AWS KMS and never leaves it; the managed path's key is held by its wallet provider through AgentCore payments; no key ever appears in code, prompts or logs	Accepted; amended by P-23	A fooled model or a crashed check still cannot overspend, and a key the code never holds cannot leak through it	Only ever tightened
P-07	Every payment is bound to its receipt: the x402 settlement response, with its transaction hash, is stored with the request, and escrow covers a service that takes the money and fails to deliver	Accepted; amended by P-24	An agent never pays without a record of what it bought, and Base cannot settle the payment and the delivery as one step	Module 6
P-08	Readers onboard with Coinbase embedded wallets and sponsored smart-account gas, and agents pay with x402's signed USDC authorizations, whose gas the facilitator pays	Accepted; amended by P-24	Beginners never buy gas before a first payment, and agents manage one balance instead of two	Module 7

ID	Decision	Status	Why	Revisit when
P-09	Solidity for on-chain code, tested with Foundry, and Python for everything else: web3.py for the chain, x402's Python SDK for payments, Strands Agents for the agents and AWS CDK for the infrastructure	Accepted; amended by P-24	Python covers every tool off the chain, and Solidity has the most tutorials and AI coding help for a beginner	If a needed tool has no Python version
P-10	The six safety habits carry over unchanged: release manifest, fail-closed write-back gate, kill switch with named steps and dated drills, test-set gate, near-miss log and per-run cost ceiling	Accepted	None of them depended on the chain or the cloud	Each rung gate
P-11	The chain records what must never be edited, such as allowances, payments and escrow deadlines, and any off-chain index can be rebuilt from it	Accepted	Anyone can verify the money, and losing the index costs nothing	Module 10
P-12	Superseded by P-20, and P-23 now restores AWS. P-12 had kept AWS as the cloud: KMS for keys, Lambda for the agent, DynamoDB for the index and a budget that blocks the agent's roles	Superseded	P-23 records the current reasons for AWS	Not applicable
P-13	Superseded by P-26. The research charter excluded measuring fake or wash agent activity	Superseded	P-26 answers each reason: the ledgers are public, totals accuse no one, and a measurement is research rather than policing	Not applicable
P-14	The Solidity documentation, the Foundry Book and Base's documentation join the two current books as reading sources, and no book or course material goes into Git	Accepted; amended by P-24	Solidity replaces Move, and the books' and course's copyright and the Student Code of Conduct bar sharing them	Never, for the Git rule
P-15	The plan stays dateless: modules close on checks, rungs close on gates, and dates return when the capstone course begins	Accepted	A gate holds the bar where a date invites lowering it	When the capstone course begins
P-16	Superseded by P-25. Keep the Ambition name and its public repository, with the GitLab mirror and the MIT License unchanged	Superseded	The platform's subject is agency, and the name now says so	Not applicable
P-17	The paid service charges over x402 on Base Sepolia, through the public testnet facilitator	Accepted; amended by P-24	x402 has an official Python SDK and Base support, and the testnet facilitator needs no API key	If the testnet facilitator closes

ID	Decision	Status	Why	Revisit when
P-18	Apply for Base's Creator Grant Program for the education track, for Base Builder Grants once something ships, and to a later Base Batches startup cohort	Accepted; amended by P-24	A grant can fund the build and an independent audit, and each program targets work on Base	When each program opens its next round
P-19	Superseded by P-21. The first committee had eight units and four specialists	Superseded	P-21 keeps the book's seven units, with the on-chain payments analysis inside the Sector Specialist	Not applicable
P-20	Superseded by P-23. Google Cloud was the platform: Cloud Run, Firestore, Cloud Workflows, Cloud Scheduler, Cloud KMS, Apigee and a VPC Service Controls perimeter, with Gemini agents and a Claude judge on Vertex AI	Superseded	AWS settles x402 on Base natively, and the book's disciplines do not depend on Google's services	Not applicable
P-21	The research committee has seven units, matching Figure 13.1 of the book: the Research Director; the Market Analyst; the Micro Economist (the book's Macro Economist, retooled for agent markets); the Sector Specialist, which includes the on-chain payments analysis and the Genuineness Estimate, Base first, then Tempo, then Solana and Sui; the Findings Generator (the book's Thesis Generator); the Compliance Agent as a gate; and the Report Writer. It runs on AgentCore Runtime	Accepted; amended by P-23, P-24, P-26, P-27 and P-28	Each data domain keeps one owner, and the committee keeps the book's shape: three specialists under the Director	When the agent specifications set each unit's module and cost
P-22	Tests and the kill switch follow the book, scaled to the capstone. Every commit runs a 50-query smoke set; the golden set of 200 or more queries runs when a unit joins and at each rung gate, on Bedrock batch inference; the gate is 0.90 on the golden set and 4.5 on the five-point judge scale; a canary takes 5% of traffic after 24 hours of shadow running. The kill switch runs from a CloudWatch alarm through SNS to a Lambda function that sets a DynamoDB flag, adds an AgentCore Policy rule denying every payment tool, pauses the schedules and denies the agents' roles; API Gateway and every service check the flag	Accepted; amended by P-23	Full runs at joins and gates catch regressions at a fraction of a nightly run's cost, and the kill switch must stop the gateway as well as the agents	If a regression slips between gates, the nightly run returns
P-23	AWS is the platform, in us-east-1 and serverless first: AgentCore Runtime, Memory, Gateway, Identity, Policy, Evaluations and payments; Bedrock models pinned by tier, with the Compliance judge from a different vendor than the generators; Lambda, Step Functions, EventBridge, DynamoDB, S3, API Gateway, CloudFront and KMS; CDK in Python, deployed by GitHub Actions through OIDC. This supersedes P-20 (record)	Accepted	AWS pays for things on Base natively, keeps everything in Python, and is the cloud the degree teaches	Rung-3 cost and Well-Architected review, or when Agency Lab first holds private data

ID	Decision	Status	Why	Revisit when
P-24	Base is the chain, with Base Sepolia as the only network until an independent audit, Solidity for contracts and x402 for paid services. This supersedes P-02 (record)	Accepted; amended by P-27	Base carries the most x402 dollars, AWS's payment service settles on it, and its funding programs target agentic commerce	Rung-3 review; if Sui's Agent Payments reaches mainnet with an official x402 kit; or after a full quarter in which MPP's on-chain value tops x402's on Base (P-27)
P-25	The platform's name is Agency Lab, never "Agency" alone; the repositories are renamed `agency-lab` as a separate step, and the mission and MIT License are unchanged. This supersedes P-16 (record)	Accepted	The platform studies and teaches agency, and "Lab" makes a common word searchable and says what the platform is	Only if the mission changes
P-26	The research charter measures genuine agent activity: the Sector Specialist publishes a quarterly Genuineness Estimate for x402 and MPP as a permissive and a strict share with a confidence band and a published, versioned method; it publishes totals only, never a public verdict on a named address, agent or business, reads mainnet ledgers without ever sending a mainnet transaction, and calibrates on labeled examples from its own agents and a scripted bot on test networks. This supersedes P-13 (record)	Accepted	The ledgers are public, published totals accuse no one, and no one publishes a method others can rerun	At the rung-5 gate, or before any output names an address, agent or business
P-27	Tempo and its Machine Payments Protocol (MPP) are the second rail Agency Lab measures and teaches; Base stays the only build chain, MPP sessions are reported as a named blind spot, and an optional MPP lesson on Tempo's test network follows rung 3 once AWS confirms AgentCore payments can fund a Tempo testnet wallet (record)	Accepted	The field has two agent-payment standards, x402 still carries far more money, and a referee that watches one cannot claim neutrality	Rung-3 review, or after a full quarter in which MPP's on-chain value tops x402's on Base
P-28	Agency Lab is described as a Micro Research and Education Platform (MREP), spelled out at first use in every document; the book's case study is called its Macro Research and Education Platform in full, and the committee's economist becomes the Micro Economist (record)	Accepted	The platform studies agent micropayments and the microeconomics of agent markets, and the shared acronym keeps the mapping to the book's chapters	If larger agent payments, such as consumer checkout, become most of what the desk measures

Plain-language terms

Term	Plain meaning
AgentCore	AWS's set of managed services for running AI agents: a runtime, memory, a tool gateway, identity, policy, evaluations and payments

Term	Plain meaning
AgentCore payments	AgentCore's payment service, which pays x402 and MPP bills from a Coinbase or Stripe wallet within a session budget
Agentic commerce	AI agents buying and selling on their own, paying per request in digital dollars
Allowance	The most an agent may spend, for how long and to whom, enforced by a contract
API Gateway	An AWS service that gives code a public web address and decides which function answers each request
Atomic transaction	A set of steps that all succeed or all fail together, so nothing is left half done
AWS Budgets	AWS's spending alarms, which can also block chosen roles once the bill passes a set amount
AWS CDK	A toolkit for describing AWS resources in Python code, so the whole setup can be reviewed, tested and rebuilt
Base	Coinbase's layer 2 blockchain, built on Ethereum
Base Sepolia	Base's free test network, where all of Agency Lab's money is test money
Batch inference	Sending model requests in bulk to be answered within hours, at half the usual price for the Bedrock models that offer it
Bedrock	AWS's service for calling AI models from several vendors, authorized by AWS roles instead of a separate API key
Bedrock Guardrails	Bedrock's filters for prompts and answers, including a check that an answer is grounded in its source
Block	A numbered batch of transactions the network has recorded, like a page in its record book
CloudWatch	AWS's logs, metrics and alarms service
Cost ceiling	The most one agent run may spend on models and services; near it the agent switches to a cheaper model, and at it the run stops
DynamoDB	AWS's database that stores records by a key and needs no server to manage
Embedded wallet	A wallet created inside an app when a person signs in with email or a social login, with no browser extension
Escrow	Holding a payment until the service delivers, then refunding it if a deadline passes
EventBridge Scheduler	An AWS service that starts a job at a set time or on a repeating schedule
Facilitator	A service that checks an x402 payment and records it on the chain, paying the gas
Fail closed	When a check breaks, times out or lacks the data it needs, its answer is no
Finality	The point after which a blockchain payment can no longer be reversed
Foundry	A toolkit for writing, testing and deploying Solidity contracts
Gas	The small fee a blockchain charges to run a transaction, paid on Base in ETH

Term	Plain meaning
Genuineness Estimate	Agency Lab's quarterly estimate of what share of agent-payment traffic comes from genuine AI agents rather than scripts, tests or wash trading, given as a range with its method (P-26)
Gasless payment	A payment whose gas someone else pays, so the payer needs only the stablecoin
GENIUS Act	The 2025 US law that sets who may issue a payment stablecoin and how it must be backed
IAM role	A set of AWS permissions that code takes on for a short time, instead of holding a password or key
Kill switch	A fast way to stop an agent: here, revoking its allowance, pausing its schedules, denying its role and blocking its payment tools
KMS	AWS Key Management Service, which keeps keys inside secure hardware and signs with them there
Lambda	AWS's way to run a function without managing a server; it runs on demand and bills per request
Layer 2	A blockchain that bundles many transactions and settles them on another chain, such as Ethereum, which makes each one cheaper
Near-miss log	A record of every payment the gate refused or sent for approval, with its reason, read for warnings before a real loss
OIDC	A standard that lets GitHub prove who it is to AWS and receive short-lived credentials, so no AWS key is stored
Paymaster	A contract that pays other people's gas, here within a limit Agency Lab sets
Rail	The network and rules a payment travels on, such as a blockchain or a card network
Release manifest	One file per deploy listing exactly which model, prompts, tools, contracts and allowances are running
secp256k1	The type of cryptographic key Ethereum and Base use to sign transactions
Sequencer	The computer that puts a layer 2's transactions in order; on Base, Coinbase runs it
Smart account	A wallet run by contract code instead of a single key, so its own rules can limit what it pays and someone else can pay its gas
Solidity	The programming language for contracts on Ethereum and Base
Spend Permissions	Coinbase's shared contract that lets a smart wallet's owner give a spender an allowance per token and per time window
Stablecoin	A token designed to hold a steady value, such as USDC at one US dollar
Step Functions	AWS's service for running a multi-step process in order, with retries and waits
Strands Agents	AWS's open-source Python framework for building agents
Synthetic dollar	A token that tracks a dollar through offsetting trades rather than cash reserves
Tempo	A blockchain built for stablecoin payments by Stripe and Paradigm, live since March 2026, with fees paid in stablecoins rather than a token of its own
Test network	A practice blockchain where all money is free and worthless

Term	Plain meaning
Test set	A fixed list of tasks with known right answers that every change must pass
Traffic class	A tag on every model call saying what it was for, such as an agent run, a test or a reader request, so costs can be split by purpose
Transaction hash	The unique ID of a transaction, used to look it up on a block explorer
Validator	A computer that checks and records a blockchain's transactions
Wash trading	Payments an owner makes to itself or to a partner to inflate activity figures
Well-Architected Framework	AWS's six-pillar checklist for judging a cloud design
Write-back gate	The checkpoint between what an agent proposes and anything that changes the world, such as a payment
x402	An open standard for paying per request over the web's "402 Payment Required" response, governed by its own foundation
X-Ray	AWS's tracing service, which follows one request through every service it touches

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